

Non-Specialist Governance, Not Non-Specialist Authorship: An Operational Treatment of the Accessibility Commitment in the Coordination Knowledge Substrate Pattern

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This work derives from and formalizes the Coordination Knowledge Substrate (CKS) pattern introduced in *Coordination Outside the Model: A Human-Governed Substrate Pattern for AI Systems* (Li, April 2026). It does not introduce new axioms. Its sole contribution is to formalize, at full operational depth, the **non-specialist-governance** commitment named in §7.4 of the source paper — articulating the governance-vs-authorship distinction the commitment rests on, enumerating the four authorship roles the commitment distinguishes governance from, and naming the three architectural commitments that jointly produce the accessibility the commitment names. Subsequent notes specialize the governance-vs-authorship distinction, the four authorship roles, and the three architectural commitments as standalone derivations; this note is the integrating frame.

Abstract

The CKS pattern's source paper commits to **non-specialist governance** as one of the architectural properties Claim 5 carries (§7.4) — the commitment that a non-specialist can exercise the inspect, modify, and override rights over substrate content and orchestration rules in tools they already use, without specialist platforms or specialist expertise. The commitment is load-bearing and frequently misread, in two opposite directions. Read as "non-specialists can do everything in CKS," the commitment over-claims accessibility — authorship of substrate schemas, orchestration rules, cells, and initial content typically requires specialist expertise the architecture neither claims nor demands of non-specialists. Read as "governance requires authorship expertise," the commitment under-claims itself and collapses governance into a labor commitment the source paper explicitly distinguishes governance from. This note formalizes the precise content of the commitment as the integrating frame for three subsequent derivations. It states the governance-vs-authorship distinction at the action level, enumerates the four authorship roles the commitment distinguishes governance from, names the three jointly necessary architectural commitments that produce the accessibility the commitment carries, states what the commitment does *not* claim, gives an integrating-level operational test, and closes with the strategic motivation for naming the integrating frame as standalone.

1. Why the integrating frame needs to be formalized as standalone

The non-specialist-governance commitment is one of the most consequential commitments the source paper makes for downstream architectural posture and is among the most easily misread. Its parent foundational note A1.11 names the commitment at the integrating-frame level. This note formalizes that commitment at full operational depth — articulating in derivation form what the governance-vs-authorship distinction means, which authorship roles the commitment distinguishes governance from, and which architectural commitments together produce the accessibility the commitment names.

Three motivations make standalone-as-integrating-frame treatment necessary.

The first is implementation precision. Without precise specification of what is architecturally accessible (governance) and what may require specialist expertise (authorship), implementations drift in two opposite directions. They either over-engineer for full accessibility — treating all substrate interactions as non-specialist-feasible, which produces architectures that fail under operational pressure when authorship complexity outruns accessibility limits and the system is asked to deliver an accessibility commitment it never made. Or they under-engineer — treating governance as requiring authorship expertise, which limits the architecture's accessibility benefits to specialist deployments and forecloses the accessibility benefits the source paper commits to. Both drifts produce architectures that misrepresent the commitment, and both are avoidable when the integrating frame is precisely specified.

The second motivation is the strategic prior-art posture. Non-specialist governance is consequential prior art because it forecloses architectures that conflate governance with authorship in either direction. Patentable derivations covering accessible AI architectures, non-specialist AI governance systems, or commodity-tool AI infrastructure are substantially more defensibly contested when the governance-vs-authorship distinction is publicly formalized as standalone. Naming the distinction operationally at the integrating-frame level — and decomposing it into three subsequent specializations — places the public prior-art claim where adjacent architectural moves cannot easily skirt it.

The third motivation is the connection to the labor allocation framework named in A1.12. A1.12 specifies three modes by which substrate content can be produced — direct human labor (Mode 1), LLM-under-rule labor (Mode 2), and stable-cell automation (Mode 3). Non-specialist governance is the architectural commitment that *governance authority is the same across all three modes*. The two commitments compose: A1.12 specifies the labor modes; A1.11 specifies that governance is mode-independent and accessible to non-specialists regardless of which mode produced the content the non-specialist governs. The integrating frame for non-specialist governance must keep that mode-independence visible so the composition with A1.12 is not lost.

2. The governance-vs-authorship distinction, named at the integrating level

The architectural distinction the non-specialist-governance commitment rests on operates at the action level. The full standalone treatment of this distinction is given in a separate decomposition note; this section names it at the integrating level so its role in the integrating frame is clear.

Governance actions are exercised over existing substrate content. The three rights named in A1.01 — inspect (A2.01), modify (A2.02), override (A2.03) — operate over substrate content and

orchestration rules that already exist. Governance produces no new substrate elements; it exercises authority over what is already there. The architectural commitment per A1.11 is that governance actions are accessible to non-specialists.

Authorship actions produce new substrate elements. Authorship produces what governance is exercised over: substrate schemas, orchestration rules, cells, and initial substrate content. The architectural commitment per A1.11 is that authorship actions are *not* required to be accessible to non-specialists. Specialist expertise may be needed for some or all authorship roles, depending on what is being authored and how complex the deployment's coordination patterns are.

The distinction is load-bearing because it specifies precisely which accessibility is architectural (governance) and which is not (authorship). A reader who collapses the distinction reads CKS as either over-claiming accessibility (every substrate interaction non-specialist-feasible, including authorship) or under-claiming it (governance requires authorship-level expertise). Both readings misrepresent the architectural commitment.

3. The four authorship roles, named at the integrating level

The non-specialist-governance commitment distinguishes governance from four operationally distinct authorship roles. The full standalone treatment of the four roles is given in a separate decomposition note; this section names them at the integrating level so the scope of "authorship" the commitment distinguishes governance from is enumerated rather than left implicit.

Schema authoring. Defining the substrate's structural form — entity types, relationships, field constraints, schema evolution rules. Schema authoring typically requires expertise in domain modeling, data architecture, and the specific coordination patterns the deployment is designed to carry.

Rule authoring. Defining the orchestration rules per A2.04 that determine cell-level behavior — specifying what cells can read, write, and produce under what conditions, and how cells respond when substrate state triggers a rule's preconditions. Rule authoring typically requires expertise in the deployment's coordination logic, the rule expression formats the implementation uses, and the cell-behavior patterns the rules govern.

Cell authoring. Defining cell behavior under rules — what operations cells perform over substrate, how cells interact with the LLM mediator (A1.04), what constitutes valid cell output. Cell authoring typically requires expertise in cell-execution patterns and orchestration mechanics.

Initial content authoring. Producing the substrate content the deployment starts with — the initial entities, decisions, relationships, and state that populate the substrate at launch. Initial content authoring typically requires domain expertise in what the deployment is coordinating about.

The four roles are operationally distinct from each other; each typically draws on different expertise, and a deployment may have different specialists exercising different roles. The architectural commitment per A1.11 is that *governance does not require any of the four authorship expertises*. A non-specialist who has not exercised any of the four roles can still inspect, modify, and override the resulting substrate content within authorized scope.

4. The three architectural commitments producing accessibility, named at the integrating level

Non-specialist governance is operationally feasible because of three architectural commitments composing. The full standalone treatment of the three-commitments specification is given in a separate decomposition note; this section names them at the integrating level and asserts the joint-necessity structure that makes the composition load-bearing.

Tool-agnosticism per A1.05. The substrate's three minimal requirements — persistent structured state, human read/write access, and LLM access (the operational commitments decomposed in A2.24–A2.26) — are satisfiable by commodity tools: file systems, document repositories, spreadsheet applications, web interfaces, mainstream collaboration platforms. Non-specialists govern substrate through tools they already use. No specialist platform is architecturally required.

Authority-not-labor per A1.01. The architectural object humans govern is the authority structure over substrate content, not the labor of producing it. The three rights operate over substrate content regardless of who or what produced it — direct human labor, LLM-under-rule labor, or stable-cell automation per A1.12. Non-specialists exercise authority without needing to produce the content they govern, which is precisely what makes governance accessible without authorship expertise.

Linear-cost per A1.06. Governance cost is not size-proportional, as A2.33 establishes. The cost of exercising governance scales with intervention frequency, which is a deployment choice, not with substrate size. Non-specialists govern substrates of arbitrary size with cost bounded by the rate at which they choose to intervene, not by how much content the substrate carries.

The three commitments are jointly necessary. No single commitment, nor any pair, suffices to produce non-specialist governance. If tool-agnosticism per A1.05 is missing, governance becomes platform-bound: non-specialists must use a specialist platform to exercise the three rights, and the commodity-tool accessibility the commitment names is lost. If authority-not-labor per A1.01 is missing, governance collapses into authorship: exercising the three rights requires producing substrate content, and the accessibility decoupling the commitment names is lost. If linear-cost per A1.06 is missing, governance becomes cost-prohibitive at scale: non-specialists can in principle exercise the three rights but cannot do so over substrates of operationally meaningful size, and the accessibility degrades to a small-substrate-only property. The three commitments are not three independent contributors to accessibility; they are three jointly necessary conditions whose composition produces the architectural property A1.11 names.

5. What the non-specialist-governance commitment does NOT claim

Stating precisely what the commitment does not claim is what keeps the integrating-frame treatment from drifting into something stronger than the source paper supports.

It does not claim that authorship is non-specialist-accessible. The four authorship roles named in §3 may require specialist expertise depending on what is being authored. The architectural commitment is to governance accessibility, not to authorship accessibility. Source-paper §7.4 explicitly notes that

non-specialist authorship is POC-demonstrated in a regulated-industry setting but is not an architectural requirement that follows from the design pattern alone.

It does not claim that maintenance is non-specialist-accessible. Substrate maintenance — keeping content current as the underlying work evolves, updating schemas as deployment patterns shift, adapting rules as new coordination needs emerge — is a category distinct from both governance and authorship. The architectural commitment is to governance accessibility, not to maintenance accessibility. Source-paper §7.4 treats non-specialist maintenance, like non-specialist authorship, as POC-demonstrated rather than architecturally required.

It does not claim that all governance actions are equally simple at the operational level. Inspect actions per A2.01 may be operationally straightforward in many deployments; modify and override actions per A2.02 and A2.03 may require domain understanding to exercise meaningfully. The architectural commitment is to accessibility through the three rights using commodity tools, not to all governance actions being equally simple. The simplicity gradient across the three rights is a deployment property, not an architectural one.

It does not specify implementation patterns for non-specialist governance. Implementations may use various tools, interfaces, and workflows to support non-specialists. The architectural commitment is to the three commitments per §4 being operationally satisfied, producing accessibility that non-specialists can exploit through commodity tools. The specific tools and workflows are deployment choices, not architectural requirements.

It does not foreclose specialist governance roles. Deployments may have specialists who exercise governance alongside non-specialists. The commitment is to non-specialist governance being feasible — not to all governance being non-specialist. A deployment in which both specialists and non-specialists exercise governance satisfies the commitment, provided the non-specialist exercise is architecturally supported.

It does not claim that non-specialist governance produces outcomes equivalent to specialist governance. Non-specialists may exercise governance with different intervention patterns, different override decisions, or different inspection frequencies than specialists would. The architectural commitment is to the accessibility — that the three rights are exercisable by non-specialists in commodity tools — not to outcome equivalence between specialist and non-specialist exercise. Whether the two produce equivalent outcomes is a domain-specific property the architecture does not commit to in either direction.

6. Operational test at the integrating-frame level

A system instantiates the non-specialist-governance commitment at the integrating-frame level if and only if all of the following are true.

1. The governance-vs-authorship distinction holds operationally — the three rights per A2.01–A2.03 are exercisable independently of the four authorship roles per §3. A non-specialist who has not exercised any authorship role can still inspect, modify, and override substrate content within

authorized scope.

2. The four authorship roles per §3 are operationally distinguishable; substrate content produced under any of the four roles is governable by non-specialists who have not exercised the role that produced it.
3. The three architectural commitments per §4 are operationally satisfied — tool-agnosticism per A1.05 (commodity-tool sufficiency for the three minimal requirements), authority-not-labor per A1.01 (governance over content regardless of producer), and linear-cost per A1.06 (governance cost not size-proportional). All three must hold; partial satisfaction degrades the accessibility the commitment names.
4. Governance accessibility holds across the three labor modes per A1.12; non-specialists govern substrate content regardless of whether the content was produced by Mode 1 (direct human labor), Mode 2 (LLM-under-rule), or Mode 3 (stable-cell automation).
5. The accessibility is architectural-pattern-level, not deployment-feature-level. Specific deployments may operationally enhance accessibility through additional tooling, training, or workflow design, but the architectural commitment is to the underlying accessibility produced by the three architectural commitments per §4 — not to any particular tooling, training, or workflow a deployment chooses to add on top.

A system that fails any of (1)–(5) does not instantiate the commitment at the integrating-frame level. The component-level operational tests for the governance-vs-authorship distinction, the four authorship roles, and the three architectural commitments are specified in their respective standalone decomposition notes.

7. Why naming the integrating frame as standalone matters

Implementations under pressure to position CKS as broadly accessible drift, predictably and steadily, toward over-claiming non-specialist accessibility. The drift is rhetorically appealing — broad accessibility presents better than narrow accessibility — and commercially familiar, since vendors typically position systems as widely accessible to broaden the addressable user base. The drift produces architectures where accessibility claims fail under operational pressure: when authorship complexity outruns non-specialist capability, the system appears to fail an accessibility commitment it never made, and the architecture's actual commitment — governance, not authorship — is obscured by the over-claim.

Implementations that drift in the opposite direction — collapsing governance into authorship, treating non-specialist governance as requiring authorship expertise — produce architectures where the accessibility benefit the commitment names is lost. The three rights become specialist-only operations, the commodity-tool feasibility tool-agnosticism establishes is bypassed, and the architecture loses one of its load-bearing properties without naming the loss.

Naming the non-specialist-governance integrating frame as a standalone architectural commitment — with the governance-vs-authorship distinction in §2, the four authorship roles in §3, the three jointly

necessary architectural commitments in §4, the bounded set of non-claims in §5, and the integrating-level operational test in §6 — gives downstream readers a precise specification of what accessibility the architecture commits to. The subsequent decomposition notes specialize each component in operational depth. Together with this integrating frame, they give the full operational decomposition of the non-specialist-governance commitment A1.11 names.

Subsequent work that adopts the CKS pattern, extends it, composes it with adjacent patterns, or argues against it should use "non-specialist governance" in the sense formalized here. Subsequent work that uses the term differently — as a commitment to non-specialist authorship, non-specialist maintenance, or universal substrate-interaction accessibility — is using a different concept, and the difference should be named.

Source paper

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